

Team Training · All Departments

People Buy People.

Master the Art of Connection.

Marketing Sweet · Whole-Team Training

WHAT THIS SESSION IS The single skill that runs through Sales, Customer Service, Accounts, Marketing, and Leadership. Before any client buys the product, trusts the advice, or chooses to work with you, they make one decision: do I trust this person? This session is about how to genuinely become that person — through listening better, adapting to who's in front of you, and remembering that the strongest relationships are built one conversation at a time.

1. Everything comes back to people

Whichever department you sit in, your career eventually comes back to the same thing. People. Before someone buys the product, they decide whether they trust the person selling it. Before someone trusts your advice, they decide whether they trust you. Before a colleague backs you inside the business, they decide whether they respect you. Every professional interaction runs on that quiet, invisible trust decision — and the people who develop the skill of earning that trust have careers that look completely different from the people who don't.

"Before someone buys your product, before they trust your advice, before they choose to work with you — they make one decision. Do I trust this person?"

2. The misconception about scripts

A common belief inside sales specifically, but the same misconception appears in customer service too: that people buy because someone has the perfect script. They don't. People buy from people they like. And they like people who make them feel comfortable — not people who deliver the most polished lines. Reps and CS staff who obsess over the script are optimising for the wrong variable.

Comfortable doesn't mean loud. It doesn't mean funny. It doesn't mean trying to impress. It means making the conversation about the person in front of you rather than about yourself. That shift — from performing to receiving — is what produces the felt sense of comfort buyers respond to. Same words. Completely different landing.

3. Connection is built by listening, not by talking

The single most under-practised skill in professional communication. Connection isn't built by talking more. It's built by listening better. There's a large difference between hearing someone speak and actually listening to what they said. Hearing is passive — the sound reaches your ear and your brain processes it enough to know when it's your turn again. Listening is active — you're paying attention, remembering details, showing genuine interest, letting the person feel like what they've said matters.

The buyers and customers who feel listened to are the ones who trust you. They can't always articulate why. They just know they enjoyed talking to you and would happily do it again. That felt experience is worth more than any perfectly-delivered line in any script.

"Listening means paying attention. Remembering details. Showing genuine interest. Making people feel like what they've said actually matters. That's what people remember."

4. What makes someone enjoyable to talk to

Worth pausing on. Think about the people you actively enjoy talking to. Chances are they aren't the ones who dominate every conversation. They're the ones who ask good questions. Who remember your name. Who remember something you told them weeks ago. Who genuinely seem interested in your life beyond the transactional layer of the relationship.

That behaviour makes people feel valued. And when people feel valued, they naturally trust you more. This is one of the highest-leverage habits any professional can build — because it works in every direction. It works with clients. It works with teammates. It works with managers. It works with prospects who haven't decided yet whether to speak with you again. The same behaviour produces the same effect everywhere it's applied.

5. Stop waiting for your turn to speak

One of the easiest ways to become dramatically more likeable — and it costs nothing. Most conversations quietly become competitions. Someone else is talking, and instead of listening, we're already planning our response. The listener's face looks attentive, but internally they've stopped receiving anything for the last thirty seconds because they're building their reply.

Real listening doesn't work like that. Real listening means becoming curious. Ask another question. Dig a little deeper. Let people explain themselves. The more someone talks, the more connected they begin to feel — and the more you actually learn about what will help them. Two wins from one small habit change. Reps and CS staff who develop this habit report material improvement in how their calls feel — because the calls literally do feel different when someone's paying attention.

"The more someone talks, the more connected they begin to feel."

6. Adaptability — meet people where they communicate

Not everyone communicates the same way. Some people are direct. Some are analytical. Some are emotional. Some enjoy small talk. Others want to get straight to the point. The goal isn't to change who you are for every buyer — it's to adjust HOW you communicate so the other person feels comfortable in the conversation.

That's what emotional intelligence actually is in practice. Not a personality overhaul — just enough tonal flexibility to meet the person where they naturally are. The rep who speaks the same way to every buyer is missing half their opportunities. The rep who reads the room and adapts is holding more attention, building more trust, and closing more calls without changing anything about the product they're offering.

7. The music analogy — not everyone likes the same

Think about music. Not everyone likes the same genre. Some people love rock. Others prefer classical. Some enjoy country. Others can't stand it. Preferences are personal, deep, and won't shift no matter how good the argument. People are exactly the same. You're never going to be everyone's favourite. And that's fine.

Your job isn't to be liked by everyone. Your job is to communicate in a way that gives you the best chance of connecting with the person in front of you. Some people will resonate with you strongly. Some won't, no matter what. The reps who accept this stop trying to shape-shift into whatever they think each buyer wants — which is exhausting and inauthentic — and start showing up as themselves, calibrated slightly to whoever they're speaking with.

8. Rushing kills relationships

A specific failure mode worth naming — especially in sales. Trying to force the outcome. Trying to book the meeting on this call. Trying to close the deal today. Trying to move to the next step before the current step has actually landed. Relationships don't work like that. Buyers don't work like that. The rep who's visibly rushing to get somewhere is producing exactly the buyer resistance they're trying to avoid.

Sometimes the best outcome isn't a sale today. It's building enough trust that the buyer will happily speak with you again next week. Long-term relationships always outperform short-term pressure. The rep who trusts this — and can be patient inside a single conversation — closes more deals over a year than the rep chasing every possible immediate conversion.

"Long-term relationships always outperform short-term pressure."

9. Acknowledge before you solve

When someone shares a frustration, the reflex — for helpful, well-meaning people — is to jump straight into solving it. That's a mistake. Solve mode communicates that the person's actual feelings weren't the point of the conversation. The information was. The problem was. The solution was. But the FEELING got skipped over.

The corrective is a small pause. Acknowledge first. Slow the conversation down. Let them know you've heard them. Repeat back what they said. Ask another question to check that you've fully understood. People don't just want solutions. They want to know they've been understood. That simple shift changes the entire conversation — because the person feels

heard first, and only THEN receives the help. In that order, the help lands. In the reverse order, the help feels dismissive.

10. This applies inside the business too

Everything above works with clients. It works exactly the same inside the business. Your teammates want to feel heard. Your managers want to feel heard. Your direct reports want to feel heard. The strongest teams aren't built because everyone agrees on everything — that's rare and often unhealthy. They're built because everyone in the room feels respected, regardless of whether their view carried the day.

Listening creates respect. Respect creates trust. Trust creates the teams that actually deliver. The professional who brings the same listening discipline to internal meetings that they bring to client calls builds a reputation across the business that opens doors well beyond any single deal or ticket.

"Listening creates respect. Respect creates trust. Trust creates great teams."

11. Genuine interest can't be faked

Worth stating plainly. People are extraordinarily good at detecting when someone is going through the motions of asking questions rather than actually being curious. The question sounds identical either way — "how's your week been?" — but the felt tone is completely different. The scripted asker gets a scripted answer. The genuinely curious asker gets a real one.

The solution isn't to script better questions. It's to become genuinely curious. Find out what motivates people. What they enjoy. What they're working towards. What's actually going on for them beyond the surface. The more you understand someone, the easier it becomes to help them — with the deal, the support ticket, the internal decision, whatever the context happens to be. And the curiosity has to be real, because people can feel the difference in three seconds.

12. Remember the small details

One of the easiest habits any professional can build. Remember small details about people. Names. Hobbies. Family. Something important that's happening in their life. Then bring it up naturally the next time you speak with them.

It doesn't have to be a big gesture. "How's your daughter's soccer season going?" carries more weight than any elaborate present. It's simply showing that you cared enough to remember. And those small moments — five seconds of a call — build enormous trust over months and years. Reps who do this consistently develop client relationships that competitors can't touch, because the competitor hasn't done the invisible work of remembering.

"Small details build enormous trust over time. It doesn't have to be a big gesture. It's simply showing that you cared enough to remember."

13. Confidence plus humility — carry both

The final principle. Carry yourself with confidence — not arrogance. There's a real difference, and buyers can feel both. Confidence knows that what you have to offer has genuine value. It doesn't need to prove itself by belittling anyone else. Humility approaches every conversation ready to listen first, understand first, and connect first — only then focusing on the solution.

Confidence without humility becomes arrogance and pushes people away. Humility without confidence becomes hesitation and doesn't produce the sale, the ticket resolution, or the internal decision either. Both together produce the professional buyers want to work with. Both together produce the teammate colleagues want in the meeting. Both together are the standard the strongest people in this business consistently meet.

"People don't remember the perfect sales script. They remember how you made them feel."

14. Today's challenge

The next time you speak with a client, a teammate, or anyone new — don't focus on saying the perfect thing. Focus on understanding them. Listen more than you speak. Adapt to the person in front of you. Be genuinely curious. Remember the small details. The strongest relationships, the strongest teams, and the strongest businesses are all built the same way — one genuine conversation at a time.

15. Action items — for every person in every department

1. On your next five conversations (calls, meetings, corridor chats), catch yourself planning your reply. When you notice, stop — and actually listen instead. Notice what changes.
2. Ask one more question than feels natural in the next client conversation. Just one. Watch how the buyer responds — most will open up.
3. Pick three people (clients, teammates, managers) and write down one small personal detail about each. Reference it naturally the next time you speak.
4. Practise adjusting your energy this week. If the person in front of you is fast and direct, speed up. If they're slow and analytical, slow down. Match — don't insist.
5. When someone shares a frustration, acknowledge FIRST before you solve. "That sounds hard. Let me make sure I've understood — you're saying..." Then solve.
6. Notice when you're rushing a conversation to reach the outcome. Stop. Trust that long-term relationships outperform short-term pressure. Slow the pace.
7. End the week asking: did people feel heard by me this week? Or did they feel processed? The answer tells you what to work on next week.

THE RULE OF THUMB People buy people. Listen better than you talk. Adapt to who's in front of you. Acknowledge before you solve. Remember the small details. Carry confidence AND humility together. The strongest relationships aren't built by having the perfect script — they're built one genuine conversation at a time. Because people don't remember what you said. They remember how you made them feel.